

AI ETHICS LEARNING TOOLKIT

Do we need AI?

“The technologies we believe to be bringing us into the future are actually taking us back from the progress already made.”

– Dr. Joy Buolamwini, computer scientist & digital activist

From concerns about AI’s impact on the environment to the disruptive role it has on human work, learning, and creativity, not everyone is on board with AI. Some argue that the growing tech oligarchy at OpenAI, Meta, Google, and X, are exploiting humans for profit gains. Some fear that in the quest for “efficiency” AI will displace human workers with sub-par work (aka AI slop). This section provides readings, discussions, and questions for instructors who **do not** want to introduce *use of* AI in their classrooms but would like their students to think critically about AI’s impacts on society.

Learning Activities

Conversation Starters A Few Questions to Get the Discussion Going

- Who specifically benefits from the development of AI? Who is harmed?
- What are some compelling reasons you've heard about why people *do not* want to use AI?
- What are some small, practical ways you could see yourself limiting (or opting out entirely) of AI use in your daily life? What difficulties would you face? What benefits might come from this stance?
- Pick a setting in which the use of AI makes you particularly uncomfortable. Discuss your reasons for being wary of AI in this setting. Ex. Healthcare, Schools, Government, Entertainment (tv, movies), Criminal Justice, Journalism, etc.
- Why is it difficult to imagine our world without AI?

Active Learning with AI Fun Ways to Explore AI's Strengths and Limitations

- Have students make a zine! Like [Julie Steele's Anti-AI manifesto](#), you can have students work individually, or in groups, to articulate a critique of AI through the format of a zine. [How to make a zine](#).
- Have students read [Duke's Prompt Responsibly principles](#) and discuss one principle you find the most thought-provoking or compelling. Which one is it? Why does it resonate with you?
- Take a Side/Debate. Split the class into AI boosters and Anti-AI advocates. Give them time to discuss and do some research (no AI!). Then facilitate a debate between the two sides.
- Disconnect Experiment – aside from critical tasks (school work, health, etc.), have students disconnect from phone/social

media/AI/internet-streaming for 48 hours. Keep a reflection log on how this experiment feels.



Disciplinary Extensions

Ideas for Exploring AI's Impact in Specific Fields

- **Public Policy:** Case Study – Geo Group. This is a private prison company which controls AI surveillance technology for undocumented immigrants. Students could discuss the ethics of using AI in this setting ([NYTimes article on this](#))
- **Philosophy:** Discuss whether AI can have “personhood”
- **Literature:** Technology is a frequent theme in dystopian fiction. Explore science fiction texts that present resistance to AI/technology. How do these compare to the current moment?
- **Art history:** Can AI image generators create art? Why or why not?

Resources

- Stele, J. (2024, October 3). [AI is very bad, actually: A manifesto](#). Julie Setele. [Zine] 
- O'Neil, L. (2023, August 12). [These women tried to warn us about AI](#). *Rolling Stone*. [Magazine article] 
- Mozilla Foundation. (2017-present). [IRL: Online Life is Real Life](#). [Podcast] 
 - Recent seasons are focused on AI and hosted by digital activist Bridget Todd.
- Bender, E. & A. Hanna. (2023-). [Mystery AI Hype Theater 3000](#). [Podcast] 
 - Tagline: “Artificial Intelligence has too much hype. In this podcast, linguist Emily M. Bender and sociologist Alex Hanna break down the AI hype, separate fact from fiction, and science from bloviation.”

- Black Mirror. British TV series exploring dystopian narratives related to technology. [Video]  

Scholarly

- Hicks, M. T., Humphries, J., & Slater, J. (2024). [ChatGPT is bullshit](#). *Ethics and Information Technology*, 26(2), 38. [Journal article] 
- Bender, E. and A. Hanna. (2025). [The AI Con: How to fight Big Tech's hype and create the future we want](#). Harper Collins. [Book – available in Duke Libraries]  
- Hao, K. (2025). [Empire of AI: Dreams and nightmares in Sam Altman's OpenAI](#). Penguin Press. [Book]  
- Narayanan, A., & Kapoor, S. (2025). [Why an overreliance on AI-driven modelling is bad for science](#). *Nature*, 640(8058), 312–314. [Journal article]  
- Merchant, B. (2023). [Blood in the machine: The origins of the rebellion against big tech](#). Little, Brown and Company. [Book – available in Duke Libraries]  
- Postman, N. (1998, March 28). [Five things we need to know about technological change](#). [Presentation]
- Kaczynski, T. (1995). [Industrial society and its future](#). *Washington Post*. [Manifesto] 
-  TRIGGER WARNING: This is the Unabomber's manifesto and reading it would require some background and context given to students beforehand.

Recommendations

- Related topics → All of them.
- [Bullshit Machines](#) → website developed as a critique to AI hype. Includes ideas for how to teach about it.
- [AI Pedagogy Project \(Harvard\) Assignments](#) → Filter by theme (e.g. misinformation) and/or subject (e.g. ethics & philosophy)